Reachable, Not Responsible: An Interview Study of Byline Order on the University's Fast-Turnaround Research-Output Pipeline

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Abstract. The University's stated authorship policy ties byline order to analytic contribution, following a CRediT-style attribution framework. We report a semi-structured interview study of 34 postdoctoral and early-career researchers across both Schools, each discussing the most recently published output on which they were a non-lead co-author, cross-referenced against the Office of Research Outputs' press-query correspondence logs for that release. Byline rank correlated weakly with self-reported analytic-contribution rank (Spearman's $\rho = 0.09$, n.s.) and strongly with rank order of reply speed to the press office's 48-hour pre-release query window ($\rho = 0.91, p < .001$); the association held after adjusting for seniority tier ($\rho = 0.89$). Across the sample, the fastest respondent held the first-listed position in 30 of 34 outputs; the co-author reporting the largest analytic share held it in 12. Interviewees rarely framed the association as a grievance, more often describing it as a settled convention nobody had chosen to write down. We discuss the finding as a case of a stated attribution policy persisting alongside an unstated one that answers a different, faster-moving institutional need, and consider what it implies for any research unit whose output pipeline outruns its own review cadence.

Introduction

Every research output the University ships carries a byline, and the University's stated policy is unambiguous about what that byline is supposed to communicate: order follows contribution, assessed against a CRediT-style breakdown of who conceived, executed, and wrote the work [1]. The policy is not unusual; most institutions that publish one say something similar, and most of the empirical literature on authorship exists because the policy rarely predicts what actually appears in print [2], [3], [4].

What is unusual about the University's setting is the speed at which the policy is tested. The Office of Research Outputs' fast-turnaround pipeline moves a project from final analysis to public release inside a fixed institutional cycle, and the pipeline's companion press release is drafted and quote-checked inside a 48-hour query window that opens once a release date is set. Co-authors are contacted for comment, for a quote, and for a check of the release's method paragraph; whoever answers inside the window becomes the release's institutional voice for that output, regardless of their position on it. Byline order, on the University's account, is set earlier and independently, in the manuscript's own drafting.

This paper asks whether that independence holds. We interviewed 34 postdoctoral and early-career researchers across both Schools about their most recent co-authored output, and matched their account of how the byline was decided against the Office's own correspondence logs for the same release. We make three contributions, each hedged to what an interview study of this size can support:

- We report what we believe is the first joint account of byline-order and press-query-response data for the same set of outputs.

- We characterise how strongly each is associated with the eventual byline, and find the association is strongest for a variable the stated policy does not mention.
- We describe how interviewees narrate the discrepancy, and what that narration suggests about how an unstated convention persists alongside a stated one it has quietly displaced.

The remainder of the paper reviews related work on authorship conventions and institutional decoupling (Section 2), describes the interview sample and the correspondence-log method (Section 3), reports the rank-correlation results and a seniority-adjustment check (Section 4), and discusses what a fast-turnaround output pipeline may be selecting for when it selects a byline (Section 5).

Related work

Authorship-order research is a large literature precisely because the ordering rule is rarely as clean as any single institution's policy claims. Author sequence conventions vary widely across disciplines and often fail to communicate actual contribution [2], and the perceived meaning of a given byline position varies enough between fields, and even between individuals in the same field, that the same position can be read as senior authorship in one setting and least-contributed in another [3]. Surveyed researchers report widely differing beliefs about what a given author position is even supposed to signal [5], and a systematic review of the authorship literature finds persistent disagreement, across disciplines, about the question at all [4]. Contributorship data collected against actual byline order show that position is a poor proxy for the underlying division of labour [6], and byline inclusion itself departs from contribution often enough, through honorary inclusion or ghost omission, that the CRediT taxonomy was proposed to separate what someone did from where their name sits [1], [7]. Seniority, independent of any formal contribution rule, measurably shapes author position [8], and credit-assignment conventions differ enough across disciplines that no single translation rule from contribution to position is available [9]. This unevenness echoes a longer-documented pattern in the accumulation of scientific credit more broadly, in which recognition concentrates on the basis of prior visibility rather than contribution alone [10].

A second literature concerns the availability side of our measure: a researcher's capacity and willingness to act as their own work's public communicator. Scientists vary widely in their capacity and willingness to serve as public communicators for their own work [11], and cross-national survey evidence documents how unevenly individual researchers engage with mass-media interaction around their own publications [12]. Public-communication effort is shaped by personal and contextual factors as much as by a researcher's role in the underlying work [13], and the interrelation between a research unit's mass-media relations and its internal practice has itself become an object of empirical study [14]. None of this literature, however, asks whether media availability feeds back onto the authorship record itself.

A third, smaller literature concerns what happens once a formal policy meets an operational pressure the policy did not anticipate. Formal organisational policies can become decoupled from actual practice while continuing to supply legitimacy [15], and coordination theory treats the allocation of an interdependent task, including who happens to be available to act on a shared dependency, as a first-order design problem in its own right [16]. We are not aware of prior work that measures a live media-query window against the same byline it is assumed not to touch.

Method

We sampled 34 outputs published across both Schools over the preceding academic year, drawn from the byline records of the Office of Research Outputs and stratified to include a mix of posters, papers, and both Schools (16 from the School of Emergent Priorities, 18 from the School of Continuous Improvement). For each sampled output we conducted a semi-structured interview (30-45 minutes) with one non-lead co-author — a postdoctoral fellow, research fellow, or lecturer — about how the output's byline order had been decided, coded following an established thematic-analysis procedure [17]; a sample of this size is consistent with thematic saturation in interview designs of this kind [18]. Interviewees were not asked to name co-authors outside their own account of the process.

For each output we additionally recorded three quantities. First, each interviewee's self-reported *contribution rank*: their own ranking, among the output's co-authors, of share of analytic work, elicited without reference to the eventual byline. Second, each co-author's *availability rank*, derived from the Office's press-query correspondence log. The Office opens a fixed pre-release query window once a release date is confirmed and contacts every co-author for comment:

```
0 9 * * *  press-query --output <id> --
window 48h \
                             --recipients co-
authors --escalate none
```

For co-author i we recorded response latency ℓ_i, the time in hours between the query being sent and that co-author's first reply within the window; a co-author who did not reply before the window closed was coded at the window's ceiling, $\ell_i = 48$. Availability rank is the ascending rank order of ℓ_i across an output's co-author set, rank 1 denoting the fastest reply. Third, each co-author's *byline rank*, their position in the output's published author list, rank 1 denoting the first-listed author.

We computed Spearman rank correlations between contribution rank and byline rank, and between availability rank and byline rank, across the full 34-output sample. As a robustness check, we re-computed both correlations after partialling out each interviewee's seniority tier (professor or associate professor; postdoctoral fellow or research fellow; lecturer), to test whether an apparent availability effect was simply tracking a seniority effect already documented in the literature [8].

Results

Contribution rank showed no appreciable association with final byline rank across the 34 sampled outputs (Spearman's $\rho = 0.09$, $p = .62$); the interviewee reporting the largest self-reported analytic share held the first-listed byline position in 12 of the 34 outputs (35%), close to what team size alone would predict by chance. Availability rank showed a strong association with final byline rank ($\rho = 0.91$, $p < .001$): the fastest respondent to the Office's pre-release query held the first-listed position in 30 of the 34 outputs (88%). Figure 1 plots both relationships together.

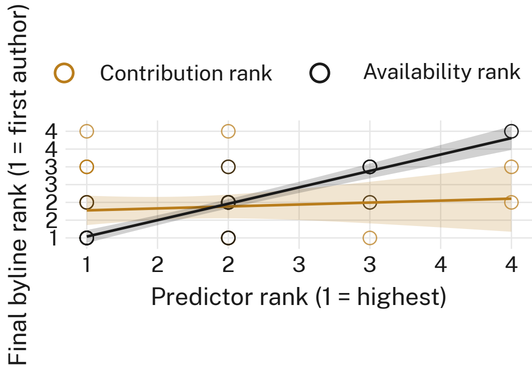

Figure 1: Predictor rank against final byline rank across 34 sampled outputs. Availability rank (rank order of reply speed to the Office's 48-hour query window) tracks byline rank closely; self-reported contribution rank does not.

Figure 2 breaks the availability relationship down by tercile of response speed. Byline rank concentrates at rank 1-2 for the fastest-responding third of interviewees and at rank 3-4 for the slowest-responding third, with the middle tercile occupying the intermediate positions the overall correlation predicts.

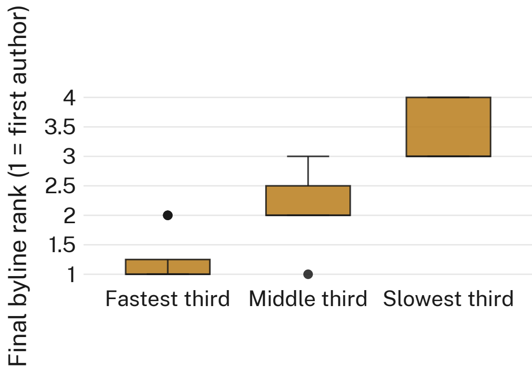

Figure 2: Distribution of final byline rank by tercile of press-query response speed ($n = 34$). The fastest tercile clusters at the first-listed position; the slowest tercile clusters at the last.

We tested whether the availability association was simply a proxy for seniority, since more senior researchers may both reply faster and be listed earlier for reasons the literature already documents [8]. Partialling out seniority tier left both correlations materially unchanged: the availability-byline correlation moved from $\rho = 0.91$ to $\rho = 0.89$, and the contribution-byline correlation moved from $\rho = 0.09$ to $\rho = 0.07$ (Figure 3). We retain the unadjusted correlations as the primary result, since the adjustment changes neither coefficient by a margin the sample can distinguish from noise.

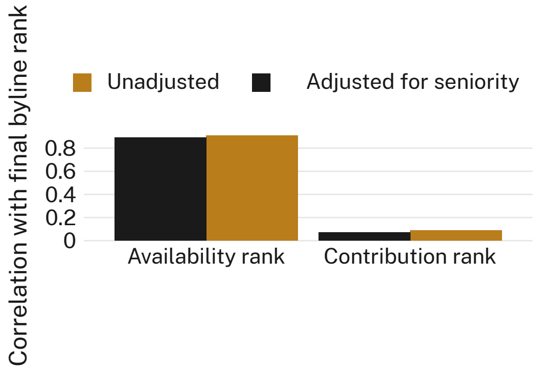

Figure 3: Correlation between each predictor and final byline rank, unadjusted and adjusted for seniority tier. Controlling for seniority moves neither coefficient (n.s.).

In the interviews themselves, few respondents described the association as a grievance. The most common frame, offered independently by interviewees across both Schools, treated the connection as settled practice rather than an open question: several used a version of the phrase "whoever's actually awake" to explain a recent byline decision, and multiple interviewees traced their own current position on a paper to a release cycle in which they happened to be between teaching commitments and could answer the Office's query the same afternoon it arrived. A smaller number described the convention as inherited from a predecessor's habit rather than any documented rule, consistent with an unwritten practice that has come to stand in for a written one it was never reconciled against [15].

Discussion

The University's authorship policy states that byline order should reflect contribution, and nothing in our sample suggests the policy is disputed or actively resisted; interviewees mostly did not describe the two orderings — the one contribution would predict and the one availability predicts — as being in tension at all. What our results suggest is a case in which a stated attribution rule and an unstated but far more predictive one coexist because they answer different institutional clocks: the manuscript's own drafting has no fixed deadline, while the Office's press-query window has a hard 48-hour close. A researcher whose analytic share is undisputed but who is teaching, on leave, or simply asleep when the window opens has, on the evidence here, a materially lower chance of appearing first. This is consistent with formal-structure accounts in which a stated policy persists as legitimating cover for a practice actually driven by an unrelated operational pressure [15], and with coordination-theory treatments of task allocation under a shared, time-bound dependency [16]. It is also, on the evidence of the interviews, not experienced by most participants as a problem worth escalating — which may be closer to an explanation of the pattern's persistence than anything about the pipeline's speed.

Limitations

Our sample covers one institution's single press office and one 48-hour query convention; a slower or less centralised release process might show a weaker availability effect, though we would expect any fixed external deadline layered onto an otherwise unhurried drafting process to produce a structurally similar result. Contribution rank is self-reported rather than independently audited, which could understate genuine agreement between contribution and byline in cases we were unable to verify; if anything, this suggests the true correlation between contribution and byline rank is at least as low as we report, not lower. Thirty-four outputs across two Schools is a modest base for a partialled correlation, though the consistency of the association across both Schools and across posters and papers alike suggests the pattern is not specific to either genre.

Conclusion

We interviewed 34 postdoctoral and early-career researchers about how byline order was decided on their most recent co-authored output, and matched their accounts against the Office of Research Outputs' own press-query correspondence logs. Byline rank tracked reply speed to a 48-hour pre-release query window far more closely than it tracked self-reported analytic contribution, and the association survived adjustment for seniority. Interviewees mostly narrated the pattern as settled practice rather than a live dispute. Future work will examine whether a documented, contribution-first byline protocol changes the pattern once it is actually enforced against the query window, or simply gives the existing practice a policy to sit alongside; a revised authorship guideline is understood to be under review by the Office of Research Outputs.

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